

Abbreviations on paper comments

These are abbreviations I use, when giving comments. It might also be of some use as a guide to things to avoid in your writing.

?

I need to read the sentence(s) multiple times to understand what you're trying to say. Consider paraphrase to make the sentence(s) clearer and easily accessible to the reader.

??

What do you mean by this? I'm having trouble understanding what you're trying to say. Please clarify or say more so that the reader can understand. Possible issues include:

1. the sentence(s) are grammatically incorrect or awkward stylistically;
2. you assume background knowledge that is not shared by the reader;
3. the key words/phrases in the sentence(s) are inaccurate or inappropriate to express what you want to say;
4. The ideas are unclear/confusing.

V

This is vague/philosophically loaded. You need to specify or clarify what exactly you mean here.

RR

"repetitive", i.e. here you're repeating something you've just said, either in the same or only slightly different words.

CNS

"Claims not supported": you are making claims without providing evidence or arguments that support those claims. Or at least, it is not obvious to the reader how these claims are not supported. Please say more to explain/support them.

ANO

"Arguments, not opinions": you are telling me your opinion on something, not giving me an argument.

Example: I do not find Popper's position attractive.

I don't care if you find Popper's position attractive. I care whether you have arguments to establish that his position is wrong, or objections and criticisms to the arguments he makes in favour of his position.

ND

"Not a democracy": philosophical disputes are not resolved by majority votes.

Example: Most philosophers are unconvinced by Popper's arguments.

Are you sure? I bet the reading didn't include a statistically significant opinion poll. But even if it did, who cares? What matters are what the arguments for and against Popper's view are, not the percentage of people convinced by them. This is philosophy, not sociology.

NN

“Name names”: don’t use the locution “some philosophers say” and similar without saying who you mean.

Example: Some philosophers argue that realism can be defended from the pessimistic meta-induction by careful consideration of the history of theory change.

Who? If you actually are thinking of a particular person, say who. Otherwise, it’s better to say something like “One possible defense of realism is...”. What matters is the argument, not whether some people are making it.

AS

“Avoid ‘Surely’”: in general you should avoid the words “surely”, “clearly”, “obviously”. As a rule, they are used (often unconsciously) to paper over weak spots in an argument.

Example: According to Dennett’s intentional stance, thermometers have beliefs in at least a weak sense. But surely thermometers don’t have beliefs in *any* sense. So Dennett must be wrong.

There’s no actual argument being given here for the claim that thermometers don’t have beliefs. Maybe it’s just intended as a premise. But either way, adding “surely” is just a bit of rhetoric; it’s not an argument.

(Conversely, look out for when other people say “surely”—often, it tells you where the hole in their argument is!)

DIF

Does It Follow? You’ve used an entailment term like ‘thus’, ‘so’, ‘therefore’, ‘hence’, ‘this implies...’ or ‘it follows that...’, but what comes after the entailment term doesn’t actually follow from what came before it, or at least I can’t figure out how it does. I might also leave this comment if you say something like “If X then Y” or “Y, since X” or “X. Accordingly, Y.”, and I don’t see how X is supposed to support or explain Y or why I’m supposed to infer Y from X.

Alternatively, perhaps you’ve said that a certain thesis entails a certain thing (e.g., “If hedonism is true, then...”), and I think you need to walk the reader through how to get from the thesis to the alleged consequence. Or perhaps you haven’t explicitly told us what that thesis is, and I’m unable to assess whether it’s true that the thesis has that implication.

Get into habit of seeing these entailment terms as “whiplash words”. When you’re editing your paper, and you see one of these terms, your head should whip back to what was previously said, to check that you’re “earned” your ‘thus’ or ‘therefore’.

WT

The words or phrasing used to transition from one sentence to the next might not be accurate to represent the connection between the two sentences. **Or at least, it is unclear or confusing what the connection is.** For example, you might start a sentence with “For example...”, but what follows isn’t really an example of anything mentioned in the previous sentence. Or you start a sentence with “Therefore,” but what comes next doesn’t really follow from what was said in the preceding sentence(s). Or you say “In other words,” but what comes next isn’t really a reiteration of the preceding sentence. Those ones are common enough to get their own hashtags.

Look closely at the sentences and think harder about what exactly the connection is between the sentences. Hopefully, upon reflection, you will see why I think that you misrepresented the connection.

SP

This comment indicates that you need to do more to explain the pertinence of some point that you're making or the role that it's playing. How does this sentence or paragraph or section connect to the sentences or paragraphs or sections around it, and/or how does it fit into the larger structure of the paper?

Perhaps you've begun telling us what some author says, and I'm wanting you to clarify why you're telling us this. Because you're going to challenge them? Because it's an objection to something you've already said? Because it supports something you've said or that you're going to say?

Or perhaps you're mentioning some objection to an argument, and I want it to be clearer (from the start) whether it's an objection you ultimately endorse, or one you're going to dismiss as inadequate.

Or perhaps you've got a vague transition between sentences, for instance "This leads us to the following principle: ...", and I want a more precise indication of what the relation is between what you've just finished saying and the principle you're about to present. Is the principle *entailed* by what precedes it? Or is that which precedes it one premise of an argument, and the principle is going to be the second premise of the argument? Or is the principle going to be part of an objection to what precedes it?

To fix the problem, you incorporate language that can serve as "signposts" on the road that is your paper, indicating (e.g.) that we are now leaving the Town of Explaining the Argument for Hedonism, that we are now entering Smith's Bad Objection to the Argument (population: the remainder of this section), and that the Township of Your Superior Objection to the Argument is still two sections down the road.

To help see the importance of signposting, suppose you encounter a paragraph like this:

(A) Some will object that hedonism entails that knowledge isn't valuable. **The problem is that** something can be valuable without being intrinsically valuable. Knowledge is instrumentally valuable.

Notice how unclear it is what's going on in this passage. Is "the problem" a problem for the hedonism, or a problem for the objection? And why is this a problem? Now compare (A) with (B):

(B) Some will object that hedonism entails that knowledge isn't valuable. To see that this objection is misguided, notice that hedonism only says that *intrinsically* valuable things must be pleasurable. Accordingly, hedonism is entirely compatible with nonpleasurable things like knowledge being valuable, if only instrumentally. All hedonists must deny is that knowledge is intrinsically valuable.

One common issue connected to a lack of signposting is that you've transitioned too subtly, perhaps mid-section or mid-paragraph, from *presenting* some idea to *challenging* the idea, and I'm wanting a more explicit indication that this transition has occurred. For instance, perhaps you've written something like this:

(C) Hedonists often insist that putative counterexamples can be handled by attending to the difference between intrinsic and instrumental value. For instance, they will often say that, while knowledge cannot be intrinsically valuable, it is however instrumentally valuable. Knowledge must at least in some cases be intrinsically valuable. After all, [[insert argument that knowledge is sometimes intrinsically valuable]].

When first reading this, it's natural to hear the penultimate sentence ('Knowledge must...') as a continuation of the hedonist's reasoning. But in fact, as you probably realized after you read it (and then re-read it), the paragraph has abruptly shifted, without warning, from presenting the hedonist's line of thought to attacking it. What's needed here is more signposting, perhaps inserting a paragraph break after the second sentence, and beginning the new paragraph with something like:

(D) However, as we are about to see, there are some versions of the objection that cannot be handled by this sort of strategy.

TR

The transition between these two sentences (or paragraphs) is a bit sudden. You might have done signposting (see **SP**) and used the right transition words/phrases (see **WT**). However, the connection is still unclear.

You need to supply the missing info that explains how idea A leads to idea B. It's possible that your sentences are so packed that the reader needs to do the work on their own to figure out what the connection is.

It is also possible that there is no direct connection and you need to rearrange the structure of the paper.

WRS

What role does this sentence (or paragraph) serve in the paper? How (or why) is it relevant to support the thesis?

If it's relevant, you need to explain how (or why).

If it is just not relevant, you should consider cutting the sentence(s) or paragraph(s).

CE

"Category error", such as 'The number two is blue', 'The theory of relativity is eating breakfast', or 'Green ideas sleep furiously'. There is a mismatch in connecting things from two distinct categories.

NM

When an author relies heavily on nouns (especially abstract nouns) instead of using more active verbs and concrete language. Overusing nominalizations can lead to sentences that are grammatically heavier and potentially harder to parse.

Sometimes, it is not necessarily the use of nouns *in itself* that makes the writing hard to understand. The real issues arise when sentences become so abstract or packed with jargon that it's difficult to see who is doing what, or how each sentence leads to the next idea. Consider introducing more active-voice verbs that clearly show who or what is performing an action.

Q

You've included a direct quotation from some author, and I'm suggesting that if you're going to include the quote, then you should do more to explain it.

Perhaps you've included a quotation from some paper you're discussing, and I'm suggesting that you restate the quoted material in your own words and/or explain how it's supposed to relate to what you've said before or after the quote. Unless both the meaning and relevance of the quoted material is crystal clear, it's important to provide some sort of gloss in your own words, in part to get everyone on the same page about what the quoted material is supposed to be saying and how it's supposed to be relevant to what you're saying.

Or perhaps you've included some quoted material that contains jargon or allusions that the reader won't be able to understand without your help. For instance, perhaps you want to quote Garcia in support of your claim that hedonists don't have to deny that knowledge is intrinsically valuable:

(A) According to Garcia, "hedonists and other proponents of the PR-principle are, in this way, able to avoid having to deny that knowledge is inherently valuable."

Having quoted this passage, it is now your responsibility to explain to your readers what Garcia means by ‘the PR-principle’, and what (in the context of her paper) she is alluding to when she says ‘in this way’. You have to do this even if understanding the PR-principle and “this way” is otherwise irrelevant to your paper. Moreover, because she says ‘inherently’, not ‘intrinsically’, you now have to connect the dots for the reader, demonstrating how her claim about inherent value is related to your claims about intrinsic value, perhaps requiring further textual evidence that she uses ‘inherently’ and ‘intrinsically’ interchangeably.

In principle, you could avoid these issues in (A) with something like this:

(B) According to Garcia, “hedonists ... are ... able to avoid having to deny that knowledge is [intrinsically] valuable.”

With the ellipses and the bracketed replacement of ‘inherently’, you avoid having to explain the jargon, allusions, and terminological discrepancies. But the downside of (B), apart from being an eyesore, is that it’s suspicious: when readers see all these ellipses and brackets, they wonder what you’re hiding, and whether you’re manipulating the quote to say something it really isn’t saying.

In many cases, providing the needed reiteration and explanation of a quote is more trouble than it’s worth—because it ends up introducing redundancies and unnecessary complications into your paper—and the best option is simply to remove the quote.

QR

You’re relying too much on direct quotation. For instance, perhaps you’ve quoted some unremarkable sentence from an article you’re citing, leaving readers to wonder why you aren’t able to just say it in your own words. Or perhaps the quoted material does more harm than good, because it contains unclarity or jargon or because there are mismatches between the terminology you use in your paper and the terminology used in the quote (see #Q).

A rule of thumb is to directly quote from a book or article only in the following three situations.

First, you plan to circle back and scrutinize the exact wording of the quoted passage.

Second, you’re explaining some author’s view, and you suspect that readers will suspect that you’ve mischaracterized that author’s views—perhaps because the view you’re attributing to them sounds crazy, or because you know that the author is widely misunderstood, or because your response to the author is so powerful and obvious that readers will suspect you must be misinterpreting them. In such cases, the quoted material serves as evidence that the attribution is accurate.

Third, you’re trying to motivate your project. For instance, if your paper is devoted to addressing a certain objection, a few concise quotes from key figures in the debate advancing the objection can help demonstrate the significance of your paper. Otherwise, it’s typically best to avoid direct quotation and instead put things in your own words, providing citations as necessary in the footnotes.

AP

When you use pronouns in a paper, the reader needs to be able to look back to earlier in the sentence, or to the previous sentence, to figure out what the pronoun is referring to. Pronouns that have their reference determined in this way are called *anaphoric* pronouns—to be distinguished from *deictic* pronouns which get their referent by demonstration (like when I point at you and say “*that*’s my favorite philosopher”).

If I’ve left this comment, it’s because you’ve used a pronoun—often ‘this’, ‘that’, ‘they’, ‘this P’, or ‘that P’—without a clear referent. Whenever you say ‘this’ or ‘that’, there should be a clear answer to the question ‘what?’, and whenever you say ‘this F’ or ‘that F’, there should be a clear answer to ‘which P?’ Suppose you said:

(A) Whenever a hedonist makes a value judgment, **that thing** must be pleasurable.

You meant for ‘that thing’ to refer to *the thing being judged to be valuable*. But the only thing explicitly referenced earlier in the sentence is the judgment itself, so the only available reading of (A) is one that (weirdly) says the judgment itself must be pleasurable.

Next, consider (B):

(B) Hedonism seems to entail that only pleasure is intrinsically valuable. But many deny **this**.

The problem with (B) is that there are too many candidate referents for ‘this’, and thus too many possible interpretations of what it is that many are being said to deny. Many deny that only pleasure is intrinsically valuable? Many deny that hedonism has that entailment? Many deny that hedonism *seems* to have that entailment? Even if there are enough clues in the surrounding context for a charitable reader to figure out what ‘this’ is supposed to refer to, it’s best to rewrite the sentences so that the unintended readings are no longer grammatically available.

Also be careful about using ‘they’ without first explicitly introducing its referent. Consider:

(C) **Hedonism** is the thesis that only pleasure is intrinsically valuable. **They** would say that knowledge is at best instrumentally valuable.

The ‘They’ is evidently meant to refer to hedonists. But hedonists (themselves) are not mentioned in (C) and thus are not an available referent for ‘They’. To fix the problem, the first sentence could be changed to something like ‘Hedonists hold that only...’, or ‘They’ in the second sentence should be replaced with ‘Hedonists’.

Similar remarks apply to definite descriptions purporting to refer back to previously mentioned items, like ‘the objection’, ‘the counterexample’, or ‘the thesis in question’.

Get into habit of seeing these terms as “whiplash words”. When you’re editing your paper, and you see a term like ‘this’, ‘this objection’, or ‘the objection’ your head should whip back to what was just said, to make sure that the intended referent is (grammatically) within reach.